

Natural Law



Christian philosophers could base their moral philosophy on the teaching of Jesus, but extending this to political philosophy raised the question of how far the laws of man were compatible with the law of God. Augustine tackled the issue in *The City of God* (see [Reconciling faith and reason](#)), contrasting earthly society and the kingdom of God in a similar way to Plato's worlds of appearances and Forms. Taking the idea further, Thomas Aquinas suggested that human laws were separate from God's eternal laws but that there also exists a Natural Law, based on human behaviour, morals and virtues, that is a part of God's law.

An important part of Natural Law was the concept of 'Just War'. Christianity (and many other religions) preaches pacifism, but politics sometimes makes war necessary. Rather than being a contradiction of God's law, however, Aquinas suggested that war could be justified by Natural Law. Again basing his ideas on Augustine, he proposed three requirements for war to be just: rightful intention, a just cause and authority of the sovereign.